



DIGITAL SECURITY GUIDE

Clean Your Digital Life

A practical, jargon-free guide for everyday people who want to protect their privacy, stop hackers, and take back control of their online presence — in 30 days.

WRITTEN BY A CYBERSECURITY PROFESSIONAL

Complete Guide · 8 Chapters

Before You Begin

This guide is written for regular people — not IT professionals. Every step uses plain language. You do not need to be technical to follow this guide.

The goal is simple: by the time you finish, your accounts will be harder to hack, your personal data will be harder to find, and you will know exactly what to do if something goes wrong.



How to use this guide

Read it once end-to-end first, then go back and use the checklists at the end of each chapter to take action. Set aside 30 minutes a day for one week — that is all it takes to transform your digital security.



Important

Some steps will ask you to change passwords or enable security settings. Do these on your personal device, not on a work computer or public WiFi. Take your time — there is no rush.

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Why Your Digital Life Needs Cleaning

You lock your front door every night. But most people leave their entire digital life wide open — and they don't even know it.

10B+

Passwords leaked in data breaches in 2024 alone

83%

Of people reuse the same password on multiple sites

\$1,200

Average financial loss per identity theft victim

What Actually Happens When You Get Hacked

Most people imagine hackers as movie villains typing fast in dark rooms. In reality, most hacks are boring and automated. A criminal buys a list of leaked email-and-password combinations for a few dollars, runs a bot that tries them on Gmail, banking apps, and shopping sites, and within minutes finds accounts that work.

If you use the same password everywhere, one leaked breach from a website you signed up on in 2015 can hand over access to your email, your bank, your Amazon account — everything.

The Three Things That Put You at Risk

1

Weak or reused passwords

One breach = everything exposed. This is by far the most common way people get hacked.

2

No second layer of verification

Without 2FA, anyone who knows your password can log in — from anywhere in the world.

3

Oversharing and old accounts

Old accounts with outdated information get breached and forgotten. Public social media posts reveal more than you think.



The good news

You do not need to be technical to fix all of this. The steps in this guide require nothing more than a smartphone and about 30 minutes of focused time. Small changes make a massive difference.

Fix Your Passwords — All of Them

A password like "Ravi@1990" feels personal and secure. To a hacking tool, it takes under 3 minutes to crack.

What Makes a Password Weak?

Most people choose passwords based on things they won't forget — birthdays, names, favourite things. This is exactly what attackers count on. Hacking tools are trained on millions of common patterns and can try billions of combinations per second.

Password	How Long to Crack	Why
password123	Instant	In every attacker's list
Ravi@1990	Under 3 minutes	Name + year = common pattern
MyDog\$Fluffy2	Under 2 hours	Dictionary words with substitutions
T!g3r-Blue-Rain-42	Millions of years	Random words + symbols + numbers
k#9mXq!2nBvLp@7	Billions of years	Truly random, long

The Two Rules for Good Passwords

Rule 1: Long beats complex. A 16-character password made of random words ("Tiger-Cloud-Pencil-Rain") is stronger than a short password full of symbols ("P@ss1").

Rule 2: Every account must have a unique password. If one site leaks your password, attackers should not be able to use it anywhere else.



If you use the same password on more than one account

Go to haveibeenpwned.com right now, enter your email address, and see if you have already been in a known breach. It is free and safe to use. If you have — change those passwords today.

You Don't Need to Remember Them: Use a Password Manager

A password manager is an app that stores all your passwords securely. You only need to remember one master password — the app remembers everything else. It also generates strong random passwords for you.



Recommended Free Password Managers

Bitwarden — Free, open source, works on all devices. Best overall choice.

Google Password Manager — Built into Chrome and Android, easy for beginners.

iCloud Keychain — Built into Apple devices, no setup needed for iPhone/Mac users.

✓ CHAPTER 2 ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Check haveibeenpwned.com for your email address
- ☐ Install a password manager (Bitwarden recommended)
- ☐ Change passwords for email, banking, and social media first
- ☐ Generate a new unique password for every account going forward
- ☐ Never reuse a password — let the manager generate and store them

Two-Factor Authentication

Even if someone steals your password, 2FA stops them cold. It is the single most effective security upgrade you can make today.

What is 2FA?

Two-factor authentication (2FA) means that logging in requires two things: something you know (your password) and something you have (your phone). Even if an attacker has your password, they cannot log in without also having access to your phone.

Think of it like a door with two locks. One key is stolen — but the second lock still keeps the door closed.

Types of 2FA (Best to Worst)

1 Authenticator App — Best

Apps like Google Authenticator or Authy generate a 6-digit code that changes every 30 seconds. Cannot be intercepted by SMS attacks.

2 SMS / Text Message — Good

A code is sent to your phone by text. Better than nothing, but can be intercepted via SIM-swap attacks.

3 Email Code — Acceptable

A code is sent to your email. Only as safe as your email account — always secure your email first.



Where to enable 2FA first

Prioritise these accounts in this order: **Email (Gmail/Outlook)** → **Banking apps** → **WhatsApp** → **Instagram/Facebook** → **LinkedIn** → everything else.

How to Enable 2FA on Gmail (Step by Step)

1 Open Gmail on your phone

Tap your profile picture → "Manage your Google Account"

2 Go to Security

Tap the "Security" tab at the top of the screen

3 Tap "2-Step Verification"

It will show as Off. Tap it, then tap "Get started"

4 Choose your method

Select "Authenticator app" for best security, or "Text message" as a starting point

5 Save your backup codes

Google will give you 10 backup codes. Screenshot them and save in a secure place. These let you in if you lose your phone.



Enable 2FA on WhatsApp too

WhatsApp accounts are frequently hijacked. Go to **Settings** → **Account** → **Two-step verification** → **Enable**. Set a 6-digit PIN you will remember. This stops someone from stealing your WhatsApp number.

✓ CHAPTER 3 ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Install Google Authenticator or Authy app
- ☐ Enable 2FA on your primary email account
- ☐ Enable 2FA on your banking apps
- ☐ Enable two-step verification on WhatsApp
- ☐ Enable 2FA on Instagram and Facebook
- ☐ Save backup codes somewhere safe (not in email)

Hunt Down and Delete Old Accounts

That forum you joined in 2011, the food delivery app you used once, the photo-sharing site that shut down — they all still have your data.

Why Old Accounts are Dangerous

Every website you have ever signed up on stores your email address, password (or a hashed version), and often your name, phone number, and location. When that site gets breached — and small sites get breached all the time — that data ends up in criminal databases.

You probably have 50–150 accounts you have never thought about. Many still have your old passwords. Some have your credit card details. Most are security risks you are carrying around without knowing it.



The Email Search Trick

Open your email inbox and search for **"welcome"**, **"verify your email"**, **"confirm your account"**, and **"thank you for signing up"**. Every result is a site you signed up on. Go through them and delete any account you no longer need.

How to Delete Accounts Quickly

Many websites hide their account deletion option or make it deliberately confusing. Use **justdeleteme.com** — it is a free directory that links directly to the account deletion page for hundreds of popular websites. It also rates how difficult each site makes deletion (Easy, Medium, Hard, Impossible).

What to Do With Accounts You Keep

1

Update the password

Use your password manager to generate a new, unique password for every account you decide to keep.

2

Remove saved payment methods

Delete stored credit/debit card details from any shopping site you rarely use.

3

Check connected apps

Many accounts let you log in via Google or Facebook. Review and remove any app connections you no longer use. (Google: myaccount.google.com → Security → Third-party apps)



"Login with Google/Facebook" risks

When you log into a third-party site using Google or Facebook, that site can sometimes see your basic profile data. Review your connected apps regularly and remove any you no longer recognise or use.

✓ CHAPTER 4 ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Search your inbox for "welcome", "verify", "thank you for registering"
- ☐ List all accounts you no longer use
- ☐ Delete them using justdeleteme.com
- ☐ Remove saved cards from shopping sites you rarely use
- ☐ Review third-party apps connected to Google and Facebook
- ☐ Revoke access for any unrecognised connected apps

Lock Down Your Email

Whoever controls your email controls your entire digital life. Every "Forgot password?" link goes to your inbox. Secure this first.

Why Email is the Master Key

Think about what happens when you forget a password for any website. You click "Forgot password?" and a reset link goes to your email. This means: if someone gets into your email, they can reset the password for every account you own — banking, social media, shopping, everything — within minutes.



Check for secret forwarding rules right now

Attackers who gain temporary access to your email often set up a forwarding rule so all your emails secretly go to them — even after you change your password. In Gmail: Settings (gear icon) → See all settings → Forwarding and POP/IMAP. If you see any forwarding address you did not set up, delete it immediately.

Gmail Security Audit — Step by Step

1

Review recent activity

In Gmail, scroll to the bottom right corner. Click "Details" next to "Last account activity." Look for any sign-ins from unfamiliar countries or devices.

2

Check your recovery options

Go to myaccount.google.com → Security → Recovery phone and email. Make sure these are correct and belong to you.

3

Review devices

Under Security → Your devices. Remove any device you do not recognise or no longer own.

4

Enable 2FA

If you have not done this from Chapter 3, do it now. Your email must have 2FA enabled above everything else.

Your Recovery Email and Phone

Make sure your recovery email and recovery phone number are correct and up to date. If you ever lose access to your account, these are the only ways to get back in. A recovery email

pointing to an old address you no longer have access to means permanent lockout.



One more email habit to adopt

Be suspicious of any email asking you to click a link to "verify your account", "update your payment details", or "avoid suspension." Legitimate companies do not ask for passwords or card numbers via email. Go directly to the site by typing the URL — never through a link in an email.

✓ CHAPTER 5 ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Check Gmail for secret forwarding rules (Settings → Forwarding)
- ☐ Review recent login activity for unfamiliar locations
- ☐ Verify your recovery phone number and email are current
- ☐ Remove old/unrecognised devices from your Google account
- ☐ Confirm 2FA is enabled on your email
- ☐ Never click password reset links sent in unsolicited emails

Social Media Privacy Settings

Most people think privacy settings are about hiding things. They're really about controlling who can find you, track you, and use your information against you.

What Strangers Can Learn From Your Profile

A public social media profile can reveal your full name, employer, city, birthday, family members, daily routine, home neighbourhood, and vacation schedule — all without you realising. This is enough information for identity theft, targeted phishing, and physical threats.

Instagram Privacy Checklist

1 Set your account to Private

Settings → Privacy → Account Privacy → toggle on "Private Account"

2 Turn off activity status

Settings → Privacy → Activity Status → off. Stops people seeing when you were last online.

3 Remove your phone number from your profile

Settings → Account → Personal information. Your phone number does not need to be visible.

4 Review connected apps

Settings → Security → Apps and websites. Remove any app you do not recognise.

Facebook Settings to Change Immediately

1 Who can see your posts?

Settings → Privacy → Your Activity → Who can see your future posts → change to "Friends" only

2 Who can find you by phone/email?

Settings → Privacy → How People Find and Contact You → change both to "Friends" or "Only me"

3 Turn off facial recognition

Settings → Face Recognition → Do you want Facebook to be able to recognise you? → Select "No"

4

Review Off-Facebook Activity

Settings → Your Facebook Information → Off-Facebook Activity → Clear History. This shows what companies Facebook tracks you on outside Facebook.

What Not to Post — The 5 Oversharing Traps

- ✗ **Vacation photos in real time** — Announcing you are away tells people your house is empty. Post after you return.
- ✗ **Your full birthday publicly** — Birthdate is used in security questions and identity verification. Keep it off your profile.
- ✗ **Photos of your boarding pass or ID** — Even blurred photos can be enhanced. Your booking reference alone can expose personal data.
- ✗ **Location check-ins at your home** — Tagging yourself at home repeatedly creates a clear pattern of your address.
- ✗ **Complaints about your workplace security online** — Attackers look for employees who mention internal systems, software, or access issues.

✓ CHAPTER 6 ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Set Instagram to private
- ☐ Remove phone number from Instagram and Facebook profile
- ☐ Set Facebook future posts to "Friends" only
- ☐ Change "who can find you" to Friends or Only me
- ☐ Clear Off-Facebook Activity history
- ☐ Remove unrecognised connected apps from both platforms

Spot Phishing Before It Catches You

Phishing is the #1 way people get hacked worldwide. It does not require technical skill — it just requires a convincing message and a moment of distraction.

What is Phishing?

Phishing is when someone tricks you into clicking a fake link or giving away your credentials by pretending to be a trusted organisation — your bank, your company's IT team, Amazon, IRCTC, or even a friend. The message looks real. The website looks real. But you are handing your details straight to an attacker.

The 7 Red Flags of a Phishing Message

- ▶ **Urgency and pressure** — "Your account will be suspended in 24 hours." Real companies do not panic you into clicking.
- ▶ **Generic greetings** — "Dear Customer" instead of your name. If the company knows you, they use your name.
- ▶ **Slightly wrong sender address** — support@arnazon.com vs amazon.com. Look carefully at the domain.
- ▶ **Suspicious links** — Hover over (don't click) any link. The real URL shown at the bottom of your screen should match the company's real domain.
- ▶ **Unexpected attachments** — An invoice, PDF, or Word doc you were not expecting. Opening it can install malware silently.
- ▶ **Requests for personal information** — Your bank will never ask for your PIN or password in an email. No legitimate company ever will.
- ▶ **Too-good-to-be-true offers** — "You have won an iPhone! Claim now." These always lead to credential-harvesting pages.

SMS Phishing (Smishing) and Voice Phishing (Vishing)

Smishing — Fraudulent text messages. Common examples in India: fake TRAI notices saying your SIM will be suspended, fake KYC update links from "your bank", fake courier delivery messages.

Vishing — Fake phone calls. Callers pretend to be from your bank's fraud department, the income tax department, or telecom companies. They create fear ("your account is being used for illegal activity") then ask you to share OTPs or install apps.



The Golden Rule — no exceptions

Never share an OTP with anyone over the phone. No bank, no government agency, no telecom company will ever ask for your OTP. If they do, hang up immediately. A real fraud alert from your bank does not require you to share anything — they already have the information.

The 5-Second Rule Before Clicking

Before clicking any link in an email or SMS, pause for 5 seconds and ask: *"Did I expect this message? Does the sender address look exactly right? Is this creating unusual urgency?"* If anything feels off, go to the website directly by typing the URL — never through the link.

✓ CHAPTER 7 ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Memorise the 7 red flags of a phishing message
- ☐ Never click links in unexpected "urgent" emails — go to the site directly
- ☐ Never share an OTP over the phone with anyone
- ☐ If you receive a suspicious call from "your bank", hang up and call the number on the back of your card
- ☐ Enable spam filters in Gmail (Settings → Filters)

Clean Your Devices

Your phone knows more about you than any other device you own. Most people have never checked what apps are quietly running in the background.

Review App Permissions — Android

Go to **Settings** → **Apps** → **See all apps**. Tap any app, then tap Permissions. Ask yourself: does this app actually need this? A flashlight app does not need access to your contacts. A calculator does not need your location.

Permission	Who should have it	Red flag if given to
Location (always on)	Maps, Ride apps	Flashlights, games, keyboards
Contacts	Phone, messaging apps	Photo editors, utilities
Microphone	Voice/call apps, Siri/Google	Shopping apps, games
Camera	Camera app, video calling	Calendar apps, file managers
SMS / Read texts	Your default SMS app only	Any third-party app

Review App Permissions — iPhone

Go to **Settings** → **Privacy & Security**. Each category (Location, Microphone, Camera, etc.) shows you exactly which apps have requested that permission. Revoke any that seem excessive.

Keep Everything Updated

Software updates are not just about new features — 80% of updates include security patches that fix known vulnerabilities. Running outdated software is like knowing your lock is broken and not fixing it.

1 Update your phone's operating system

Settings → Software Update (both Android and iPhone). Enable auto-updates.

2 Update all your apps

Open the Play Store or App Store → tap your profile → Updates. Update everything.

Chrome, Firefox, and Safari update automatically, but check manually if you have not restarted them in a while.

Public WiFi — What You Need to Know

Public WiFi at cafes, airports, and hotels is convenient but risky. Attackers can set up fake WiFi hotspots with names like "CafeWifi_Free" that look legitimate. Once connected, they can intercept unencrypted traffic.



Safe public WiFi habits

Use your mobile data for banking and sensitive tasks. If you must use public WiFi, use a VPN — try **ProtonVPN** (free plan available). Avoid logging into banking or financial apps over public networks. Always verify the exact WiFi network name with staff before connecting.

✓ CHAPTER 8 ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Review and revoke excessive app permissions on your phone
- ☐ Update your phone's operating system
- ☐ Update all apps to their latest versions
- ☐ Enable automatic updates for OS and apps
- ☐ Delete apps you no longer use
- ☐ Never do banking on public WiFi without a VPN
- ☐ Set a strong PIN/password on your phone lock screen

Your 30-Day Digital Clean-Up Plan

Everything in this guide, broken into four focused weeks. Spend 20–30 minutes a day and you'll be done in a month.

Week 1 — Passwords and 2FA

- ☐ **Day 1:** Check haveibeenpwned.com for all your email addresses
- ☐ **Day 2:** Install Bitwarden and set a strong master password
- ☐ **Day 3:** Change email and banking passwords to strong unique ones
- ☐ **Day 4:** Install Google Authenticator. Enable 2FA on email and banking
- ☐ **Day 5:** Enable WhatsApp two-step verification
- ☐ **Day 6–7:** Update passwords for social media and top 10 most-used accounts

Week 2 — Email and Old Accounts

- ☐ **Day 8:** Check Gmail for secret forwarding rules. Review recent sign-in activity
- ☐ **Day 9:** Verify recovery phone and email are correct. Remove old devices
- ☐ **Day 10–11:** Search inbox for old signups. Make a list of accounts to delete
- ☐ **Day 12–13:** Delete unused accounts using justdeleteme.com
- ☐ **Day 14:** Remove saved payment methods from rarely-used shopping sites

Week 3 — Social Media Lockdown

- ☐ **Day 15:** Set Instagram to private. Remove phone number from profile
- ☐ **Day 16:** Change Facebook post visibility. Restrict "who can find you" settings
- ☐ **Day 17:** Clear Off-Facebook Activity. Remove unrecognised connected apps
- ☐ **Day 18:** Review LinkedIn privacy settings — limit profile visibility to connections
- ☐ **Day 19–21:** Enable 2FA on all remaining social accounts

- ☐ **Day 22–23:** Review app permissions on your phone. Revoke excessive access
- ☐ **Day 24:** Update your phone OS and all apps. Enable auto-update
- ☐ **Day 25:** Delete apps you have not used in 3+ months
- ☐ **Day 26:** Set up ProtonVPN for public WiFi use
- ☐ **Day 27–28:** Complete the Master Checklist (next page) and tick off everything done
- ☐ **Day 29–30:** Share this guide with one person who needs it. Then set a 6-month reminder to repeat key steps



After 30 days, you will have:

Unique strong passwords on every account · 2FA on all critical accounts · Old accounts deleted · Email secured · Social media locked down · Devices cleaned and updated · The knowledge to spot phishing instantly

Master Checklist

Print this page and keep it somewhere visible. Tick every item when done.

This is your complete digital security baseline.

Passwords

- ☐ Checked haveibeenpwned.com for all my email addresses
- ☐ Installed a password manager (Bitwarden / Google / iCloud)
- ☐ Every account has a unique, strong password
- ☐ No passwords are reused across any two accounts

Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)

- ☐ 2FA enabled on primary email (Gmail / Outlook)
- ☐ 2FA enabled on banking apps
- ☐ WhatsApp two-step verification enabled
- ☐ 2FA enabled on Instagram, Facebook, LinkedIn
- ☐ Backup codes saved somewhere safe (not in email)

Email Security

- ☐ No unexpected forwarding rules in Gmail
- ☐ Recent activity reviewed — no unfamiliar sign-ins
- ☐ Recovery phone and email are correct and current
- ☐ Old/unrecognised devices removed from account

Old Accounts

- ☐ Searched inbox for old signups
- ☐ Deleted all unused accounts via justdeleteme.com
- ☐ Saved payment methods removed from rarely-used sites

- ☐ Connected/third-party apps reviewed and cleaned up

Social Media

- ☐ Instagram set to private
- ☐ Phone number removed from social media profiles
- ☐ Facebook posts set to Friends only
- ☐ "Who can find you" restricted on Facebook

Devices

- ☐ Excessive app permissions revoked
- ☐ Phone OS and all apps fully updated
- ☐ Auto-updates enabled for OS and apps
- ☐ Strong PIN/password set on phone lock screen
- ☐ VPN installed for public WiFi use



Repeat this audit every 6 months

Set a calendar reminder for 6 months from today. Re-run the checklist. Update passwords for any account that had a known breach. Check for new connected apps. This is maintenance, not a one-time fix.